

Public comments by the ALS community highlight barriers to participation in science and policy

People living with ALS have firsthand insights into their unmet needs and ways to improve their quality of life [1, 2]. In healthcare policy-making processes, where decisions affect quality of life, patient participation can improve how well policies meet patients' needs [3]. However, participation can be challenging; e.g., limited feedback from institutions makes it difficult to trace whether comments by patient communities, such as pALS, had an impact on the final policies [4]. We investigate whether comments submitted by pALS can reveal barriers to institutional participation, and whether AI can trace the impact of public comments on institutional policies. We inductively coded public comments submitted by the ALS community on the federal platform regulations.gov to identify participation needs and built an AI-supported tool to trace comments to policy changes.

Our results show that people argue ALS clinical trials fail to account for the lived experience of participants enrolled in them and suggest solutions such as remote data collection, mobile trial sites, and reusing prior data to reduce patient burden and redundant studies. People also critique the federal platform for a lack of feedback, delayed review timelines that failed to match the urgency of terminal illness, and a review process that could benefit from the community's involvement. Finally, we show that the AI performs well on tracing comments relevant to multiple changes and identifies multiple themes within a single comment, but it often misses cues embedded in nuanced emotional language.

References:

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